



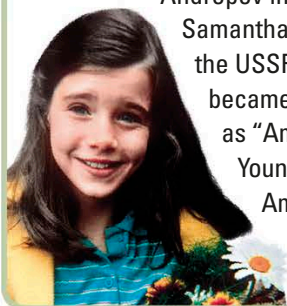
▲ DIVIDING BERLIN

After World War II, Germany's capital Berlin was split into West Berlin, under the control of the US, France, and Britain, and East Berlin, under the USSR. In 1961, the government of East Berlin built a wall dividing it from West Berlin to prevent East Berliners escaping to the West. Guards and watchtowers monitored the strip of land around the wall.

CHILD IN TIME

In 1982, 10-year-old Samantha Smith from the US wrote a letter to the Soviet leader Yuri Andropov, asking him how he would prevent a nuclear war. Samantha was troubled by news reports of the tensions between the US and the USSR. In response,

Andropov invited Samantha to visit the USSR, and she became known as "America's Youngest Ambassador."



The Cold War

The United States and the Soviet Union (USSR) emerged as powerful nations after the end of World War II. But the political differences between these two "superpowers" soon led to a struggle for dominance. Without actually declaring war, between 1946–1991, they fought a "cold war" in which they opposed each other through alliances with other nations and through the threat of nuclear warfare.

Although the US and the USSR had been allies during World War II, tensions quickly escalated during the reorganization and rebuilding of the war-ravaged countries of Europe.

The USSR took control of countries in Eastern Europe, and established communist governments in the region. Meanwhile, the US, Britain, and France supported democracy and capitalism in the countries in Western Europe. As communist influence spread to China and other parts of

Asia, the world became increasingly divided. Both superpowers backed governments in different parts of the world that supported their ideologies. They even sent weapons and troops when wars broke out in other regions—these "proxy wars" became the main battlefield of the Cold War and caused devastation in many countries.

After decades of hostilities, the Cold War came to an end with the collapse of the USSR in 1991 (see p.222).